

Why Zero Is a Result: Evidence Admission in Fiscal Analysis

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Abstract

A zero admitted saving is often treated as analytical failure. Taxlane treats it as a valid result when a candidate's evidence is insufficient for the fiscal use proposed. This paper distinguishes headline context from admitted effects, describes the evidence gates applied across fifteen tracks, and examines the benefits and risks of a conservative admission rule. The method can protect beneficiaries and fiscal arithmetic from unsupported claims, but it can also preserve a status quo if reopening rules are vague. Taxlane addresses that risk by assigning every terminal track a specific evidence trigger.

Evidence keys route to the EXPL-A claim and number ledgers. The fiscal object is Taxlane's one-year FY2026 model rail, not total federal receipts/outlays, trust-fund solvency, borrowing, or formal balance [CLM-11, CLM-12].

1. The category error

A published estimate can be real in its original context and still be unusable for a different decision. A multi-year option scored against an older baseline does not automatically supply a current FY2026 cash effect. A payment error is not automatically fraud, recoverable cash, or net savings. A broad program envelope does not specify which services change or who bears the effect.

The category error occurs when context becomes package credit without the intermediate work.

2. Taxlane's admission sequence

The sequence asks whether the source is in custody and correctly interpreted; whether the year, baseline, law, and fiscal object match; whether an executable policy and implementation path exist; whether funds and signs reconcile; whether other candidates overlap; whether burden and distribution are visible; and whether applicable service floors pass.

The gates are cumulative. Strong evidence on one dimension does not erase a failure on another. A current dollar estimate cannot substitute for a rural-access analysis. A clear policy idea cannot substitute for a score. A service floor cannot repair double counting.

3. Two examples

The health imaging option carried \$0.4 billion of FY2026 headline context [NUM-16]. It retained unresolved beneficiary cost sharing, provider response, rural and safety-net protection, diagnostic quality

and timeliness, implementation and behavior, and current-law overlap. The defense strategy carried \$15.0 billion [NUM-17] of FY2026 headline context. It retained unresolved current force and program allocation, readiness stress, community transition, procurement and industrial- base schedules, allied posture, and a current-law rescore.

Both had one ready gate and six blocked gates [NUM-18]. Taxlane admitted zero from each [NUM-03]. The original estimates remain context and are not called false. Their use as current package savings is what remains unsupported.

4. Beneficiary and public-purpose discipline

The admission rule protects more than arithmetic. Health access, education completion, food security, veteran service, disaster affordability, civil rights, energy burden, and defense readiness are not interchangeable outcome measures. A lower-cost scenario must state what continuity, adequacy, and distribution mean for the affected track.

This does not make every beneficiary claim decisive or every status quo legitimate. It means that people and public obligations cannot disappear behind a budget headline. Where a program creates reliance or legal commitments, a reopened candidate also needs a shortfall and service-continuity rule.

5. The risk of excessive caution

A high evidence threshold can freeze analysis if “more research” becomes an unbounded excuse. Taxlane avoids that outcome in three ways.

First, zero admission is terminal for the current evidence rather than an eternal queue. Second, every track names the evidence that would reopen it. Third, typed outputs survive when appropriate: a conditional cost note can be useful without pretending to be savings.

The approach still embodies a value judgment: when evidence is incomplete, Taxlane places the burden on the claim seeking package credit. Others could choose a different risk allocation. The important requirement is to disclose that choice rather than hide it in arithmetic.

6. Payment integrity and the temptation of large numbers

Payment-integrity measures are particularly vulnerable to inflation. Improper payments, fraud, gross prevented payments, returned funds, and net fiscal effects are different objects. Taxlane keeps PAY non-additive until a program owner supplies a causal, net, annual effect with appeals, burden, implementation, and distribution addressed.

The rule prevents the same measurement from being claimed centrally and again inside affected program lanes. It also prevents a control from being called a saving before cash and costs are attributable.

7. Completion without complacency

Ten tracks [NUM-02] close at reviewed zero admission. That makes the fifteen-track analysis complete under current evidence. Completion is compatible with reopening. It gives future evidence a defined decision to challenge instead of leaving an indefinite backlog.

The public-language consequence is precise: “no tested amount was admitted” is supported. “There is no waste,” “the candidate is harmful,” “the program is optimal,” and “reform is impossible” are not.

8. Conclusion

Zero can be a substantive result when it records the boundary between what is known and what a fiscal claim requires. Taxlane’s method makes that boundary auditable, preserves typed partial outputs, and gives each track a route back into analysis. Its conservatism is not neutral, but it is explicit.

Taxlane can analytically recompute a disposition when evidence changes, but it cannot change law, appropriations, eligibility, tax bases, or implementation [CLM-13].

Evidence

1. data/derived/breadth_benchmark_matrix/fifteen_track_terminal_disposition.v1.draft.json
2. data/derived/breadth_benchmark_matrix/targeted_spending_rate_decision.v1.draft.json
3. data/derived/breadth_benchmark_matrix/fifteen_track_integrated_dependency_admission_rerun.
4. docs/explanation/foundation/claim-ledger.md